



Peak moment: Bronze medallist Gulveer (right) celebrates with silver medallist Kartik Kumar after the men's 10,000m final event at the 2022 Asian Games in Hangzhou. GETTY IMAGES

promotion to *havaladar*. "Someone told me that if I won a national medal, I'd get an out-of-term promotion. I just wanted to get a national medal somehow," he recalls.

That medal would come in his debut national meet — the 2022 Federation Cup in Calicut — where he won a bronze in the 10,000m with a time of 29:22.44. When you consider how much he has improved — Gulveer's current national record is nearly two minutes faster — it seems like a relatively modest accomplishment. Gulveer, however, rates it as the most significant of his career. "It helped me get my first promotion. It was the medal that made me start believing there was something I had in me," he says.

A few months later, he won gold with a new meet record at the

National Games. That form would continue into 2023 as well. He won a bronze in the 5,000m at the Asian Championships and followed it up with the biggest medal of his career — a bronze in the 10,000m at the Asian Games in Hangzhou.

According to Surendra Singh, who once held the Indian 5,000m record, Gulveer possesses all the physical qualities of a top runner. "He has naturally great stamina. Along with that, he is a very economical runner. He has a very smooth running action. He doesn't have to fight when he's trying to keep pace with someone. In fact, when someone goes in front, it really suits Gulveer because he can follow them very well," says Surendra.

But while his talent was clear and his progress impressive, Gulveer believes what significantly aided his growth as an athlete was the opportunity to train in Colorado Springs in the USA under Scott Simmons.

Simmons, who was brought in to

help India's middle- and long-distance coaching programme in 2022, says the shift was critical. "When I came to India for the first time, I realised the weather in India in winter was not conducive to long-distance running. It was one of the key reasons why no Indian had run 5k or 10k and come out with a decent result. In terms of recovery and adaptations to training, it was problematic," he explains.

There was also an additional benefit to training in Colorado Springs: Gulveer got to test himself against a strong group of runners, including Paul Chelimo, a double Olympic medallist in the 5,000m. Gulveer wasn't the first Indian runner to benefit from running alongside stronger competitors — Avinash Sable had trained with the same group a year earlier. However, while Sable was already a seasoned runner and Olympian by then, Gulveer was still at a very early stage in his development. "At that point in his career, Gulveer was a high 28-minute runner (in the 10,000m), and he was getting a chance to compete against runners in the low 27-minute range. That played a huge role in speeding up his development as a runner," says Simmons.

The learning curve was steep, Gulveer admits. "It wasn't easy to run alongside runners of that level, at least in the beginning. I developed a lot of blisters on my feet, and initially, I wasn't even able to keep up. But now I have the confidence that I can at least match their level," he says.

Another factor in his improvement was the increased opportunities to compete. By training in the USA, Gulveer was able to participate in more high-level competitions. "In the past, opportunities to take part in international competitions simply didn't exist for Indian runners like Gulveer. Now, not only do they have the chance to train outside India at altitude, but it also serves as a base for them to regularly compete in high-level competitions. That's been a big factor in their progress," says Simmons.

Regularly competing and